

NEW ARRIVAL Manpreet Badal with Union minister Piyush Goyal after joining the BJP

MANISH RAJPUT

RENEGADE SEASON IN THE BJP

The party is poaching leaders left and right to shore up its Punjab state unit and broaden its electoral prospects. But going down that path has its own pitfalls

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

On January 18, as Rahul Gandhi's mammoth Bharat Jodo Yatra crossed state borders to enter Manser in Himachal Pradesh's Kangra district from Ghatota village in Punjab's Hoshiarpur, TV news channels were also flashing images of another development in the Congress. Party leader Manpreet Badal, the former Punjab finance minister, was joining the rival Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at their national headquarters in Delhi.

A scion of the famous Badal family of Punjab who control the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), Manpreet is not known for the political skills of his more illustrious family members. For the BJP, however, he is a prize catch all the same—one they can use to embarrass the Congress while also trying to make inroads into SAD chief Sukhbir Badal's erstwhile bastion, the core Malwa region. Since November 2021, when